

Highest peaks in different continents:

- **Asia:** Mount Everest (8848 meters)
- **South America:** Mount Aconcagua (6961 meters)
- **North America:** Mount McKinley (6194 meters)
- **Africa:** Mount Kilimanjaro (5895 meters)
- **Europe:** Mount Elbrus (5642 meters)
- **Antarctica:** Mount Vinson Massif (4,892meters)
- **Aust**ralia: Mount Kosciuszko (2,228 meters)

The Great Plains

To the east of the Rockies and the west of the Appalachian Mountains lies the great plains of North America. It covers about three - fifth of the continent. This plain stretches from the Arctic Ocean in North to the Gulf of Mexico in the South and from the Appalachian Highlands in the east to the Rockies in the west. The western part of the plains is called the High Plains spreading roughly over the foothills of the Rockies. Most of the rivers of this region have their source in the Western Highlands and the plains generally slope eastwards and southwards. They are drained by rivers like the Mississippi and the Missouri.

The Appalachian Highlands

The Appalachian Highlands do not form a continuous chain like the Western Highlands (The Rockies). These Highlands are low and wide. They have a very few peaks more than 1800m. They include the High Plateaus of Greenland, Labrador or Laurentian Plateau in Canada and the Appalachian Mountains in the United States. These old fold mountains are worn down by weathering and are much lower than the Western highlands. This region is rich in mineral reserves like coal, iron ore, copper etc., which play a vital role in the North American economy.

The Coastal Plains

The coastal plains of North America are the youngest in age. Most of the Atlantic Plain has been drowned (lies underwater). This is low and relatively plain area with sandy soil which is infertile in nature. Here swamps and marshes are abundant and the coast is indented by river mouths and bays on which many important seaports are located.

Drainage

Many rivers flow across this land and some of them following the valleys are formed by the glaciers. The Mississippi and Missouri rivers are the longest rivers in North America and together they form the fourth longest river system in the world and stretching more than 6114 km from Montana to Gulf of Mexico. After 3700km running the Missouri river joins the Mississippi river. The Mackenzie River is the second largest drainage basin of North America. It has it source from Great Slave Lake and drains into Arctic Ocean.

St. Lawrence has its origin in Lake Ontario which flows north east and drains into the Atlantic Ocean. The plateau of the west has been cut deeply by the River Columbia and its tributary which forms many Gorges called Canyons. The most famous is the Grand Canyon cut by the river

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